AK-47s rattling, bullets whizzing by. It sounded like someone throwing beehives through our window. There were four Gurkhas with me, and they unleashed a Javelin missile in the direction of the incoming fire.

Then they told me to take a seat behind the 50-cal. *Jump on, saab!*

I climbed into the gun nest, grabbed the big handles. I shoved in my earplugs, took aim through the mesh hanging from the window. I squeezed the trigger. The feeling was like a train through the middle of my chest. The sound was locomotive-like as well. *Chugga chugga chugga.* The gun spat bullets across the desert, and shell casings flew around the lookout like popcorn. It was the first time I'd ever fired a 50-cal. I simply couldn't believe the power.

In my direct line of sight was abandoned farmland, ditches, trees. I lit it all up. There was an old building with two domes that looked like a frog's eyes. I peppered those domes.

Meanwhile, Dwyer began lobbing its big guns.

All was mayhem.

I don't remember much after that, but I don't need to—there's video. The press was there, by my side, filming. I hated them being there, but I'd been ordered to take them on an outing. In return they'd agreed to sit on any images or information they gathered until I was out of the country.

How many did we kill? the press wanted to know.

We couldn't be sure.

Indeterminate, we said.

I thought I'd be in that lookout for a long time. But soon after that day I was summoned up north to FOB Edinburgh. I boarded a Chinook full of mailbags, lay down among them to hide. Forty minutes later I was hopping off, into knee-deep mud. *When the hell did it rain?* I was shown to my quarters in a sandbag house. A tiny bed.

And a roommate. Estonian signals officer.

We hit it off. He gave me one of his badges as a welcome gift.

Five miles away was Musa Qala, a town that had once been a Taliban fortress. In 2006 we'd seized it, after some of the worst fighting British soldiers had seen in half a century. More than a thousand Taliban had been